Rescui-Annie

By Paul Feig

INTRODUCTION

Whether the latest Ebola or Zika virus news has triggered your inner germaphobe, or you're just a year-round clean freak like me, you'll be able to identify with this childhood memory of Paul Feig. Middle school . . . . those in between years are rough, but if you are a germaphobe, then it's even worse, especially if gym class includes CPR training with Sergeant Korn, Coach Wendell and . . . Rescui-Annie by Paul Feig

When I was a kid, I was germ conscious. *Really* germ conscious. You see, much of childhood is set up as one big germ- and spit-spreading activity. And it seemed as if all of my grade-school peers were more than willing to put their mouths on whatever it was that I or anyone else happened to be consuming at any given moment during the day. Whenever I had a bottle of pop, at any point from age four to fourteen, it was guaranteed that within seconds of

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opening it, some kid I knew would appear behind me and utter these dreaded words: "Hey, can I have a drink?" *Every* time. And then I was stuck. Because if I dared to say no, it was sure to provoke a thoughtful and understanding response of "C'mon, ya baby. I'm not gonna drink it all."

"Yeah, but you're gonna get your *mouth* all over it." Or at least, that's what I *wanted* to say. But instead, in my true non-confrontational fashion, I'd always relent: "Uh ... okay. Here." I mean, what other option did I have? The circumstances were always the same. It would be a warm afternoon. I'd be walking home from grade school, tired and worn out from a full day of crushes and failures and overreactions. As I walked, I'd twist off the top. The bottle would give me a friendly hiss that seemed to say, "Oh, friend, are you going to enjoy me." I'd take a deep breath, releasing all the tensions of the day, raise the bottle to my lips, tilt my head back and take a drink, enjoying life to its fullest. The world seemed to melt away. And life for that one

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moment was good. That is, until the dream would be shattered when Norman would suddenly walk out of the bushes and want to backwash into my bottle.

So, I'd reluctantly give him my Squirt and he'd put his mouth on it and take a sloppy swig and I'd feel defiled as I'd watch him gulp down my once pleasure-producing soft drink. My thoughts would be torn between hoping he choked on the pop and figuring out how I could possibly salvage what was left in the bottle. Maybe I could pour out the top inch of spit-contaminated liquid, then thoroughly wipe down the mouth of the bottle with my shirttail to remove the memory of his mouth. . . . when suddenly the nightmare would worsen. Another kid would invariably walk up. "Hey, Norman, can I have a drink?"

"It's okay with me, but it's Paul's pop. Ask him."

What was I gonna say? "No, I don't mind Norman's saliva but yours is a no-go." Why did all these kids have to drink out of the same bottle

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anyway? So Norman's friend would grab the bottle and take a drink and get his stupid mouth all over it and then a gang of Cub Scouts who were friends of the kid currently drinking would show up and take their turns and after an eternity I'd get the bottle back. The top would be coated with everything our grade school served for lunch that day and the few inches of liquid left at the bottom of the bottle would have about the same viscosity as old motor oil. I'd look at it and feel queasy and feel like crying but instead would try to sound casual and say, "You guys can have the rest. I'm not thirsty anymore."

"No way. I'm not drinking that. It's all backwash." Yeah, YOURS!

Well, it was a couple of years later, when I was in junior high school, that something happened during gym class that was to prove one of the most traumatic events of the spit-and-germ-avoiding segment of my childhood. Simply put, I met a girl. And that girl's name was . . . Resusci-Annie.

"Annie," as I've affectionately come to know

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her, wasn't a girl in the standard person-who's-actually-alive sense. No, Annie was a mannequin, a life-size doll with a rubber head, a mouth, a working windpipe, a set of lungs, and a body that was in possession of neither arms nor legs. Resusci-Annie, Queen of the Latex Torso Women, was something invented by paramedics and CPR instructors to be used for the teaching of the uninitiated in the fine art of mouth-to-mouth resuscitation. Annie also had one other thing going for her . . . She was terrifying.

The first traumatic thing about Annie was that she looked like a dead person. Her face was white and rubbery, her eyes were closed, her mouth was loosely open, exposing a disturbing set of rubber teeth, and she had a full mane of greasy, matted hair on top of her head. She hardly looked like someone anybody had a chance of saving. I'd throw a blanket over her face and start contacting next of kin if I saw her lying in the street. But as far as the emergency health care community was concerned,

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Annie had one purpose in this world and that was to be revived over and over again by anyone and everyone trying to master the very practical skills of lifesaving.

Mr. Wendell told us to gather in the center of the gym as we came out of the locker room. As we walked over, we saw ResusciAnnie lying on the floor. Just then, a very large policeman with a big red drinker's face and a handlebar mustache entered the gym and walked up to us.

"Hello, gentlemen. My name is Sergeant Korn. As part of an organized effort to teach people in our community about emergency medical procedures, I'm here today to demonstrate to you the proper way to administer the life-saving technique of mouth-to-mouth resuscitation."

If learning mouth-to-mouth meant it would keep us from having to play flag football or floor hockey or having to embark on yet another pointless attempt to do enough sit-ups to try to qualify for the much-unwanted President's Physical Fitness

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Award, then I was all for it.

"And now, with the help of my good friend Resusci-Annie here," Sergeant Korn said, gesturing grandly and then chuckling at his allegedly cute comment, "I'm going to show you the correct way to administer the 'Kiss of Life.'" And then, accompanied by an aria of grunts and groans, he awkwardly got down on his knees next to Annie. He stuck his fingers into her mouth, telling us that before we did anything, we were supposed to make sure that there were no "objects" blocking the victim's throat. Sergeant Korn pinched Annie's deathly white nose, put his hand under her neck to "open the throat," took a deep breath, put his mouth on top of Annie's, and blew. I immediately started to feel a bit nauseous. Maybe it was the image of an overweight cop on his hands and knees blowing into the mouth of an oversize doll and making his already uncomfortably red face even redder that made it feel more like I was watching a very low-quality porn film than a lifesaving demonstration.

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Unsettling images of Sergeant Korn's private life with Mrs. Korn started to flood into my head. Fortunately, before I was able to ruminate on these mental pictures for too long, Sergeant Korn looked up and breathlessly said, "Resusci-Annie ... now has enough air ... to start breathing on her own again." And then he struggled to stand up again. Hearing him pant and try to catch his breath, I had a momentary flash that Sergeant Korn might keel over and that one of us would then be expected to put our newfound Kiss of Life knowledge to the test. Well, I knew one thing for sure: that "one of us" wouldn't be me.

Mr. Wendell stepped forward. "All right, you guys. Line up. You're all gonna take a turn."

Huh? Excuse me? I'm sorry, I must not have heard you correctly. It sounded like you said that we were all going to take a turn giving mouth-to-mouth resuscitation to that doll that Sergeant Korn had just had his grown man's mouth all over. That couldn't be right. I looked over at Mr. Wendell and

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saw him produce a bottle of rubbing alcohol and a rag. He dumped some alcohol onto the rag and wiped Sergeant Korn's spit off of Annie's mouth. My stomach dropped into my Keds. A wave of panic overtook me. My eyes zoomed in on Annie's mouth. White and cold and open and now dripping with an indeterminate mixture of Sergeant Korn's spit and alcohol. My head started to spin.

My mind raced. This couldn't be happening. But it was. My fellow classmates were starting to line up in front of Annie. There had to be some way out of this. It just wasn't possible that I was going to have to put my mouth on that thing. Especially after other guys in my class were about to do it, too. Something had to be done.

"Mr. Wendell, I think it's against my religion to do stuff like this."

"Feig, I don't care if you're the pope. You're *doing* this, so get in line."

There was no way around it. I was eventually going to have to give Annie the Kiss of Life. I was

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really starting to feel sick. And this was before I realized that with all the air going in and out of Annie's chest, there was a whole reservoir of lung germs inside my future Resusci-girlfriend just waiting to infect my body. I was stuck, doomed, and now the last in line. More and more spit was being deposited on Annie by the second. And now I noticed that the kid directly in front of me was Doug Blaychek. He was a nice enough guy if you met him in the hallway, but he had extremely large and droopy lips that constantly seemed to be soaked with saliva. Doug turned and gave me a big, wet smile. My life started to flash in front of my eyes.

It was Doug's turn. He kneeled down and bent over Annie. He took a loud, deep breath. I saw his back rise and fall several times as he tried to revive the lifeless rubber doll on the floor. As he moved away, I looked down. There she was. Annie. Her face was soaked. I didn't know what part of that "soaked" was spit and what part was alcohol, and I didn't care. Annie's face must now be a festering cesspool of

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disease and death.

"All right, Feig. You're up." . . . Maybe if I throw up all over it, I won't have to do it, I thought. . . . "C'mon, Feig. What is it with you? Get moving!" barked Mr. Wendell. My mind reeled. I had to do something and I had to do it immediately. But what? Think fast, I told myself. Then it hit me. *Faint.*

I coughed violently and fell over. There was immediate commotion. I hadn't been sure if they would buy my sudden and convenient fainting spell or not, but I guess that the perception of me as someone who was prissy enough to faint at the thought of giving mouth-to-mouth resuscitation was enough to convince them.

"I'LL SAVE HIM!"

It was Doug! New panic set in as I heard him stomp toward me to deliver his newly learned Kiss of Life. I was nanoseconds away from blowing my cover by screaming and running away when Mr. Wendell saved me by quickly grabbing Doug by the arm. "No, Blaychek," said Mr. Wendell, "we don't know if he

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needs mouth-to-mouth."

"He coughed really loud before he fell down," said Norman.

Sergeant Korn stepped forward and looked me over. "You said he coughed?" he asked, sounding tense and official. "Then he must have choked. Everybody step back." And with that, Sergeant Korn stuck his fingers in my mouth, pinched my nose, and kissed me.

I was home sick for three days.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier